Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

The person and the room · c01s01

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What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

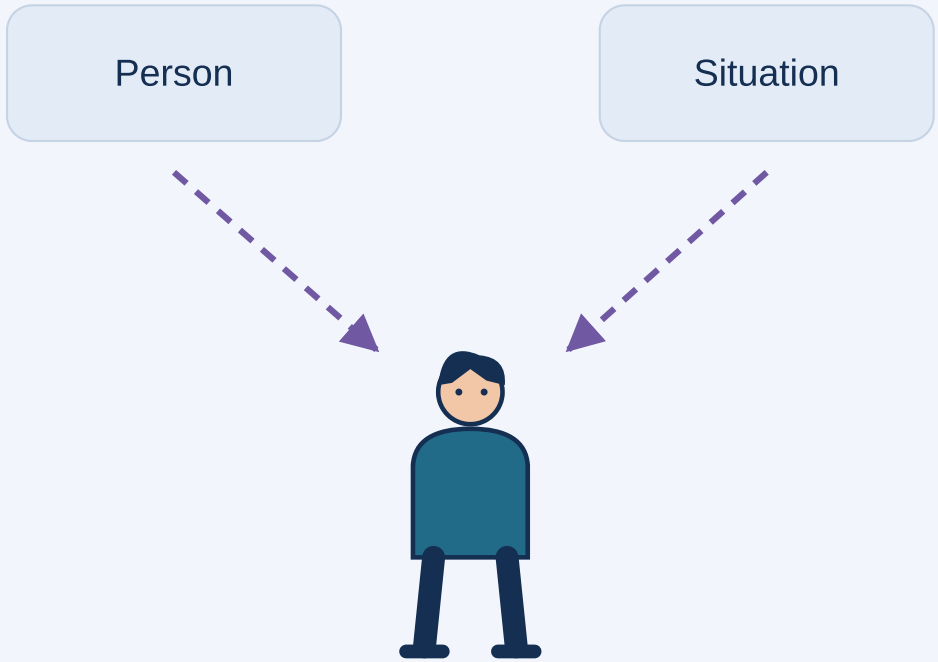
Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

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Personal qualities meet circumstances.

- **Person**: tendencies, goals, beliefs, skills
- **Disposition**: a usual tendency over time
- **Situation**: demands, people, available choices
- **Interaction**: changing circumstances can change a response

Research: OpenStax Psychology 2e: What Is Social Psychology?



Behavior emerges in context.

A disposition is one personal quality; circumstances also contribute.

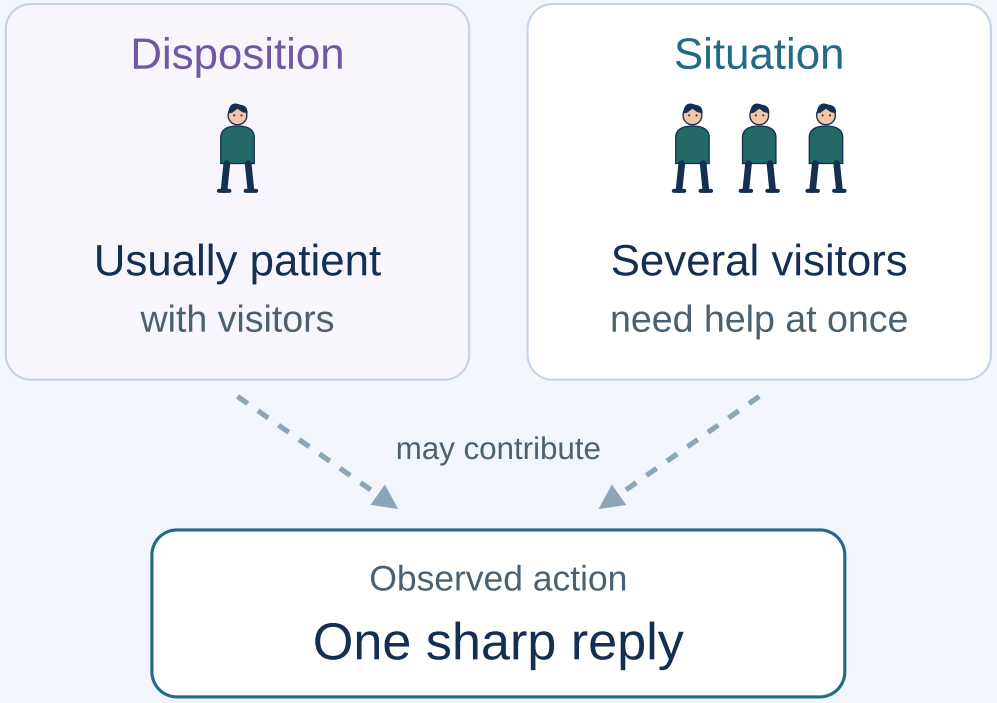
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The same person, under pressure.

- **Disposition**: the volunteer is normally patient.
- **New demands**: several visitors ask for help at once.
- **Observed action**: the volunteer gives one sharp reply.
- **Check**: compare calmer and busier shifts.

Research: OpenStax Psychology 2e: What Is Social Psychology?

A tendency meets a busy room



Compare calmer and busier shifts.

A hypothetical interaction of a disposition and a situation. Dashed paths indicate possible contributions.

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Observation and attribution.

- **Observation**: Maya arrived after the start.
- **Attribution**: an explanation of what caused an action.
- **Dispositional attribution**: a cause in personal characteristics.
- **Situational attribution**: a cause in circumstances.

Research: OpenStax Psychology 2e: What Is Social Psychology?

Two different questions

Observation



Maya arrived after the start.

A recorded action

Attribution



“She doesn’t care.”

A proposed cause

One statement records an action.
The other proposes a cause.

What evidence could test Leo’s cause?

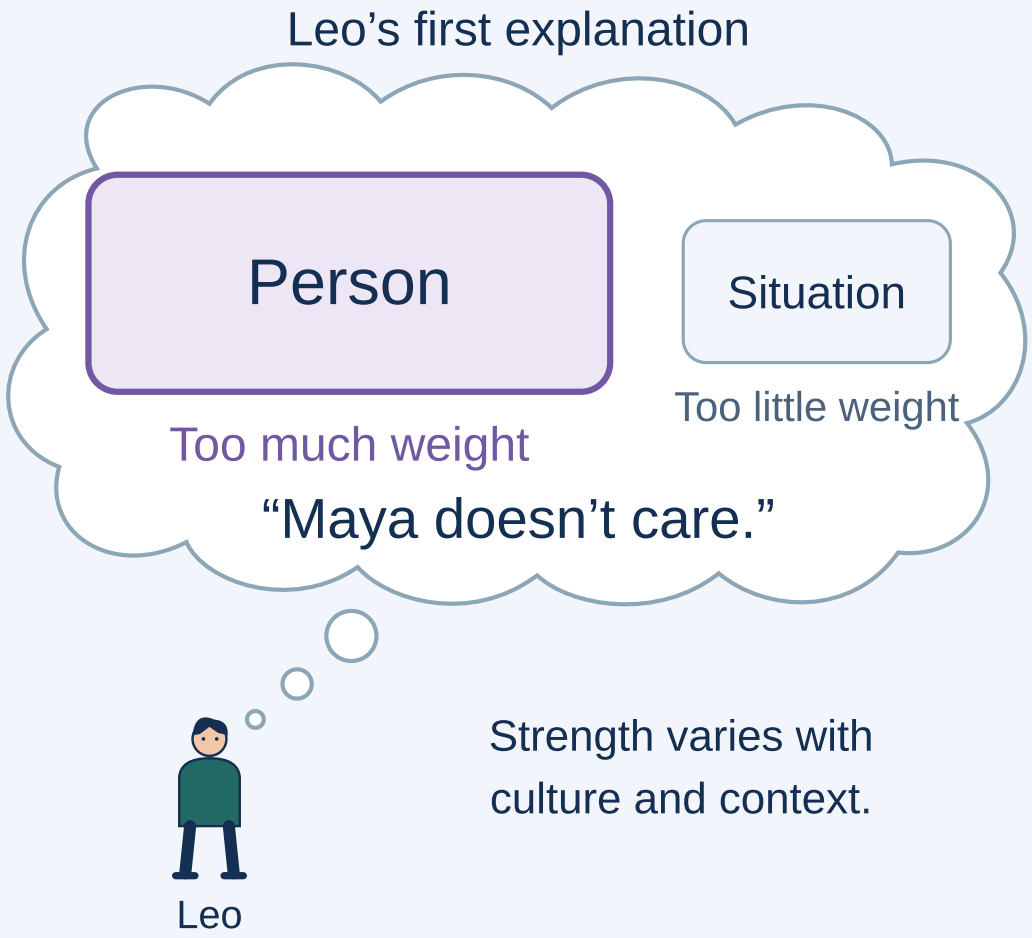
Observation records an action; attribution proposes a cause. Dispositional attribution locates a cause in the person; situational attribution in circumstances.

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When a constraint gets too little weight.

- **Fundamental attribution error**: overweighting personal characteristics and underweighting circumstances.
- **Correspondence bias**: inferring an enduring disposition from constrained behavior.
- **Leo’s inference**: lateness shows low commitment.
- **Limit**: one arrival cannot establish Maya’s disposition or diagnose Leo’s reasoning.

Research: Jones & Harris (1967) · Gilbert & Malone (1995)



Strength varies with culture and context.

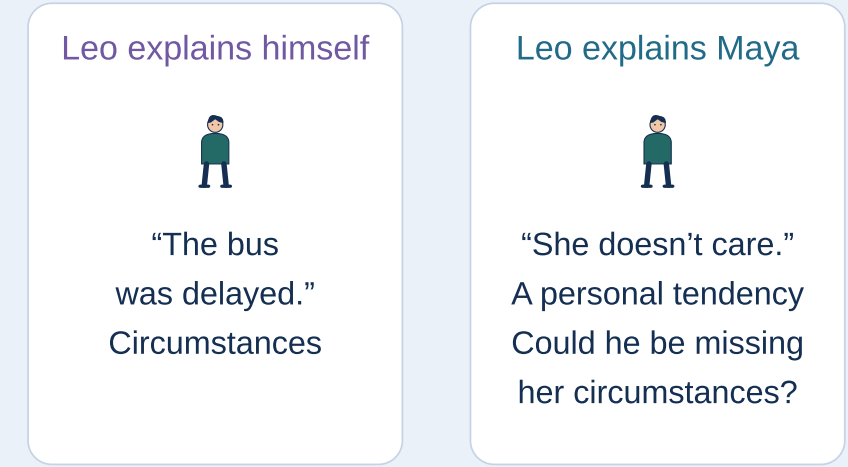
Correspondence bias concerns enduring dispositions inferred from constrained behavior. This hypothetical weighting is conceptual, not a measured effect.

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Actor–observer differences need qualification.

Attribution research examines how people explain the causes of actions and events. Those explanations do not, by themselves, settle the cause of one person’s action. The actor–observer hypothesis proposes that people explain their own actions more through situations and other people’s actions more through personal characteristics. Leo citing a bus delay for his own lateness but Maya’s priorities for hers illustrates this hypothesis. Actor–observer differences are not a general rule. A meta-analysis did not support a general asymmetry across positive and negative events; results varied with the event and research method. Keep the hypothesis, the research finding, and the fictional example distinct.

Research: Malle (2006)



Actor–observer differences do not follow a general rule across positive and negative events. These fictional explanations illustrate the actor–observer hypothesis.

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Test the explanation.

- **Describe**: Maya arrived late; “doesn’t care” is a proposed cause.
- **Compare**: look across shifts, settings, and exceptions.
- **Check**: ask Maya and test plausible alternatives.
- **Revise**: change your confidence when the evidence changes.

Research: OpenStax Psychology 2e: What Is Social Psychology? · Gilbert & Malone (1995)

Follow the evidence

Leo’s proposed cause

“She doesn’t care.”

1. **Describe the action**
   Maya arrived after the start.
   Keep the cause open.
2. **Compare occasions**
   Is lateness usual across shifts?
   Look for exceptions.
3. **Check alternatives**
   Could a travel barrier explain it?
   Ask Maya about the delay.
4. **Revise your confidence**
   Weigh the evidence for each cause.
   Allow your explanation to change.

Let evidence change your confidence.

Describe, compare, check, and revise. Apply the same steps to your own interpretations.

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Try the idea somewhere new.

Noor was late for three of six café shifts. Leo proposes bus cancellations; Maya asks whether the earlier start also matters.

Invented teaching record · six shifts

Shift conditions	Late	On time
Earlier start; bus cancelled	3	0
Later start; bus running	0	3

Which additional comparison best separates these explanations?

A Noor’s punctuality on early shifts with and without bus cancellations.

B Noor’s punctuality at a different activity reached on foot.

C Other volunteers’ punctuality on early café shifts.

Why does your comparison help? State what it keeps similar, what it varies, and one remaining limitation.

Suggested answer: A. Compare the same volunteer at the same early start time while bus availability differs. This helps separate the bus explanation from the earlier-start explanation. The comparison is observational: other conditions may change too, and six shifts give little evidence about a lasting personal tendency.

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Close your notes. Explain it.

> In Maya’s arrival story, what did Leo observe, and what cause did he infer?

> What evidence would strengthen an explanation based on a person’s usual tendencies, rather than one unusual situation?

1. Leo observed that Maya arrived after the meeting had started. He inferred that she did not care about the project. Her late arrival is the observation; not caring is his proposed cause.

2. An explanation based on a personal tendency becomes more credible when the behavior recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

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Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating action by another person. Write what you observed, your initial explanation, two plausible alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify what happened.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.

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